tonnes, with major manufacturing plants in India, several countries in Asia, the UK and Continental Europe, supported by integrated mining operations in several geographies.'

But as it turned out, this was too optimistic a view. Though by 2011 the global economic crisis had almost passed, a combination of factors dashed the chairman's hope to get Corus to work at the pre-crisis levels. The economic meltdown had changed the dynamics of the steel industry in Europe. China's aggressive pricing of its steel products in Europe, the high cost of production of steel in the UK and the general obsolescence of Corus's steel plants further diminished the hope of a recovery. The inclement economic environment and the lukewarm support that the company received from the British government also dampened its prospects. Faced with the bleak probability of a full recovery, in 2011 Corus sold its Teesside Cast Products assets. Simultaneously, a slew of reforms, including downsizing of the staff at the UK plants, was pursued.

Ratan, however, did not lose hope and said, 'Tata Steel will continue to be committed to be amongst the most cost-efficient steel companies in the world, which participates in the development of the countries where it is present, while meeting its social responsibility to its stakeholders and the communities which it serves.'

The Celebratory Goodbye

In 2012, Tata Steel created 'history by becoming the first integrated steel company in the world, [outside of Japan], to be awarded the coveted Deming Grand Prize', considered the highest award in the area of TQM. The recognition is given to 'organizations that had maintained and further enhanced the level of TQM for more than three years after the winning of the Deming Prize'. Coincidentally, it was also Ratan's last year as the chairman of both Tata Sons and Tata Steel.

In his final address to the shareholders of the company at the 2012 AGM, he stated that there was 'significant decline in steel consumption in several geographies in the western hemisphere', but that with the expansion of the capacity in Jamshedpur, Tata Steel 'would have a global steel capacity of 33.5 million tonnes'. This meant that by 2014, the capacity of the steel major would rise by nearly seventeen times since Ratan took over as chairman in 1993. Despite the economic meltdown, Tata Steel closed the